I also had the chance to reflect on my own prejudices about people within the party. For example, I was astounded that Digvijaya Singh (a former chief minister) would often be sleeping on the floor with just a gamcha (thin towel) to cover him. In stark contrast to how badly he has been caricatured in the media, he was humble and amiable, always ready to lend a hand or a patient ear. Similarly, even though a few yatris would jump into cars after only a couple of hours, I found that a majority of my fellow yatris were determined. Similarly, even though some yatris were not very friendly and would quarrel over the pettiest things, an overwhelming majority was kind, generous and friendly. I made some wonderful friends from all across India. Conversations with them made me appreciate how diverse we were as a nation and the challenges each state faced. But also that deep down, we all shared the same fears and had the same aspirations. Once we began to see that, all of us saw each other as close friends.

I recall that I was engrossed in explaining something about Kerala to Pushparaj once, who was then walking alongside me. We both came across a young Bharat yatri from Maharashtra, who was badly injured and crying. She was too shy (and I suspect a little too proud) to accept anyone's help. But Pushparaj convinced her to let us (lying about how bored we were so we could do with her company); so we helped her walk the last 2 kilometres to the resting area and to medical care. Those 2 kilometres were very difficult because she was putting her whole weight on us, so we were forced to stop for some lemon water at a wayside restaurant, where the Muslim owners refused to accept payment from either of us! But even though her foot wasn't healed, she was certainly much more buoyant and spirited. I guess she realized she wasn't alone any more. And till date, she keeps in touch. A testament to such bonds we forged was that some of my fellow yatris came from very remote corners of India to Kerala just to campaign for me in Puthupally, my constituency. I hope one day I, too, can repay the favour to each of them.

Overall Impact